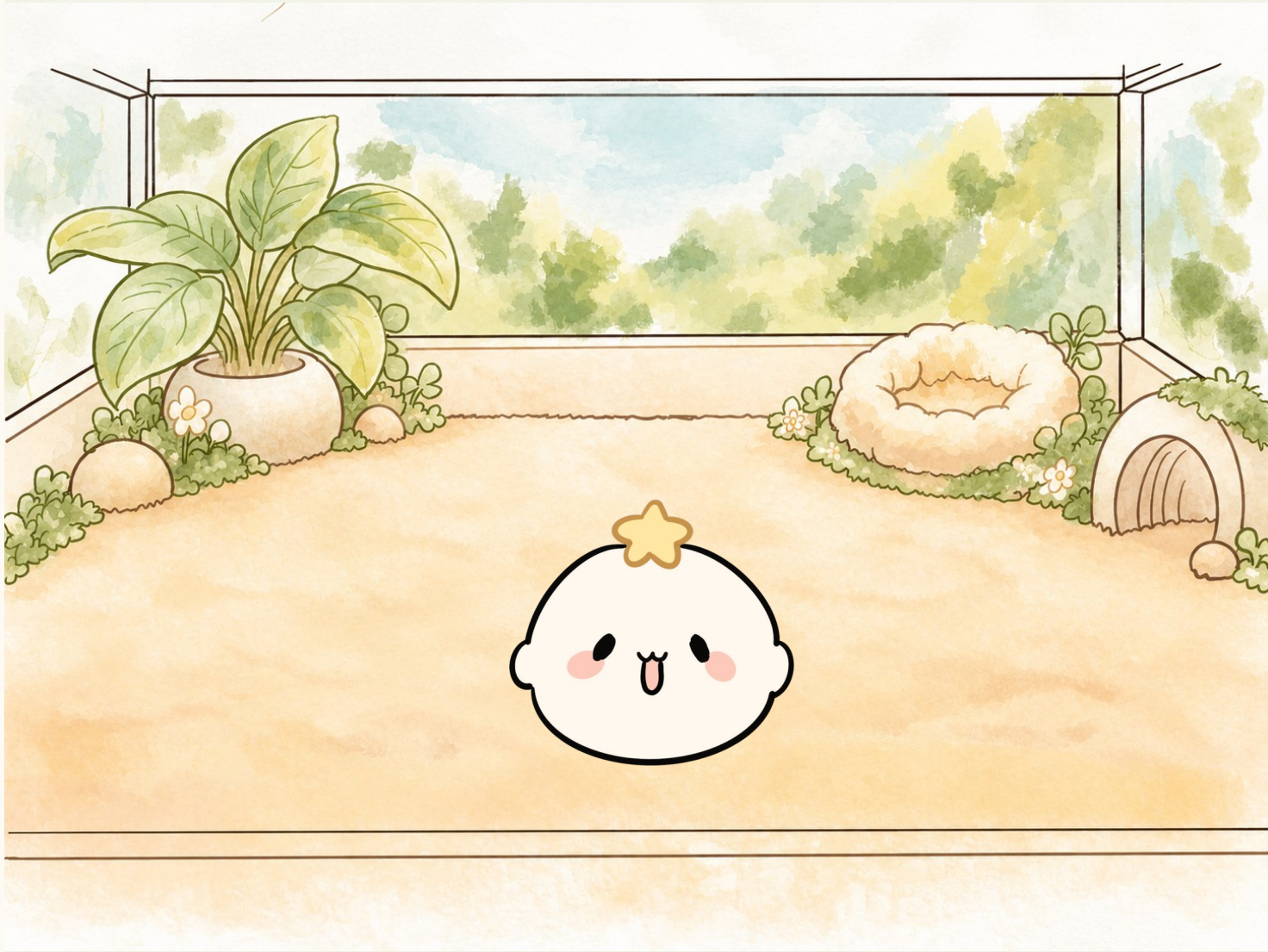
Little Rascal

A little life, shaped by care.

A playable virtual pet experience
built with p5.js



Can small acts of care create attachment?

How can caring for a simple pet create a meaningful connection?

Care → response → attachment

A short browser experience for a desktop or exhibition setting.



A companion with changing needs

Three layers of connection

01

VISCERAL

“I want to meet it.”

Soft colour, a cute silhouette and gentle sound.

02

BEHAVIOURAL

“My actions matter.”

Clear care tools, physical play and readable responses.

03

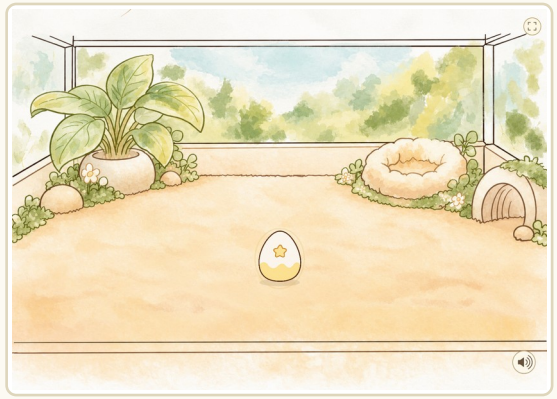
REFLECTIVE

“I cared for this little life.”

Naming, changing needs and a meaningful goodbye.

Design framework: Norman’s three levels of emotional design (2004).

From a first meeting to a new beginning

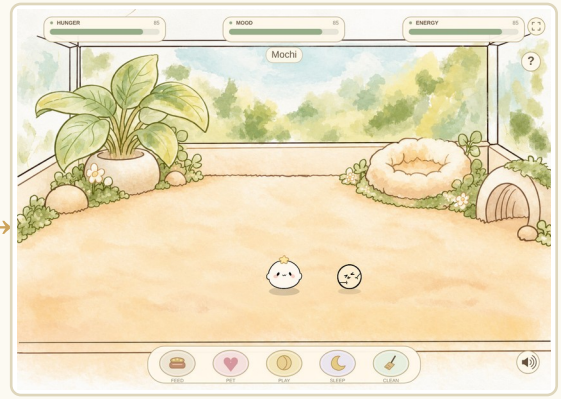


01

Meet & name

Click the egg.

Give a name.

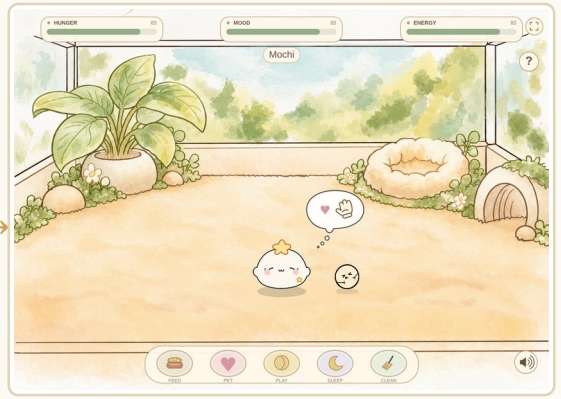


02

Care & respond

Read needs.

Choose how to care.

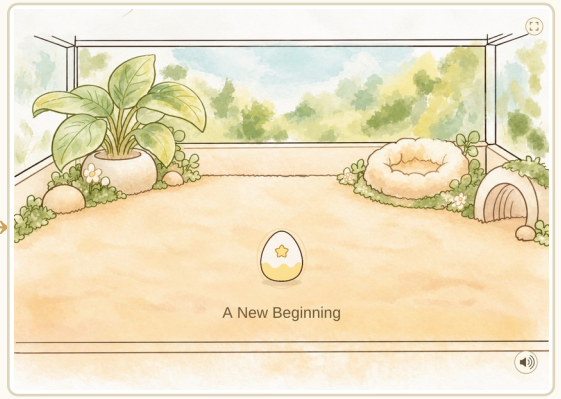


03

Grow & change

Care, then sleep.

Wake into the next stage.



04

Farewell & renew

Open the letter.

Welcome a new egg.

One character, three changing relationships



LITTLE ONE

3 useful feeds + 3 pettings.
Grow after the next waking.



YOUTH

Playful and independent.
May resist or get bored.



SENIOR

Slower, with rest breaks.
Asks for affection.

Growth follows useful care and the next waking — not a passive age timer.

Care is a conversation, not a command



Accepts

Happy feedback rewards meaningful care.



Gets bored

Repetition or a full need can lead to stillness.

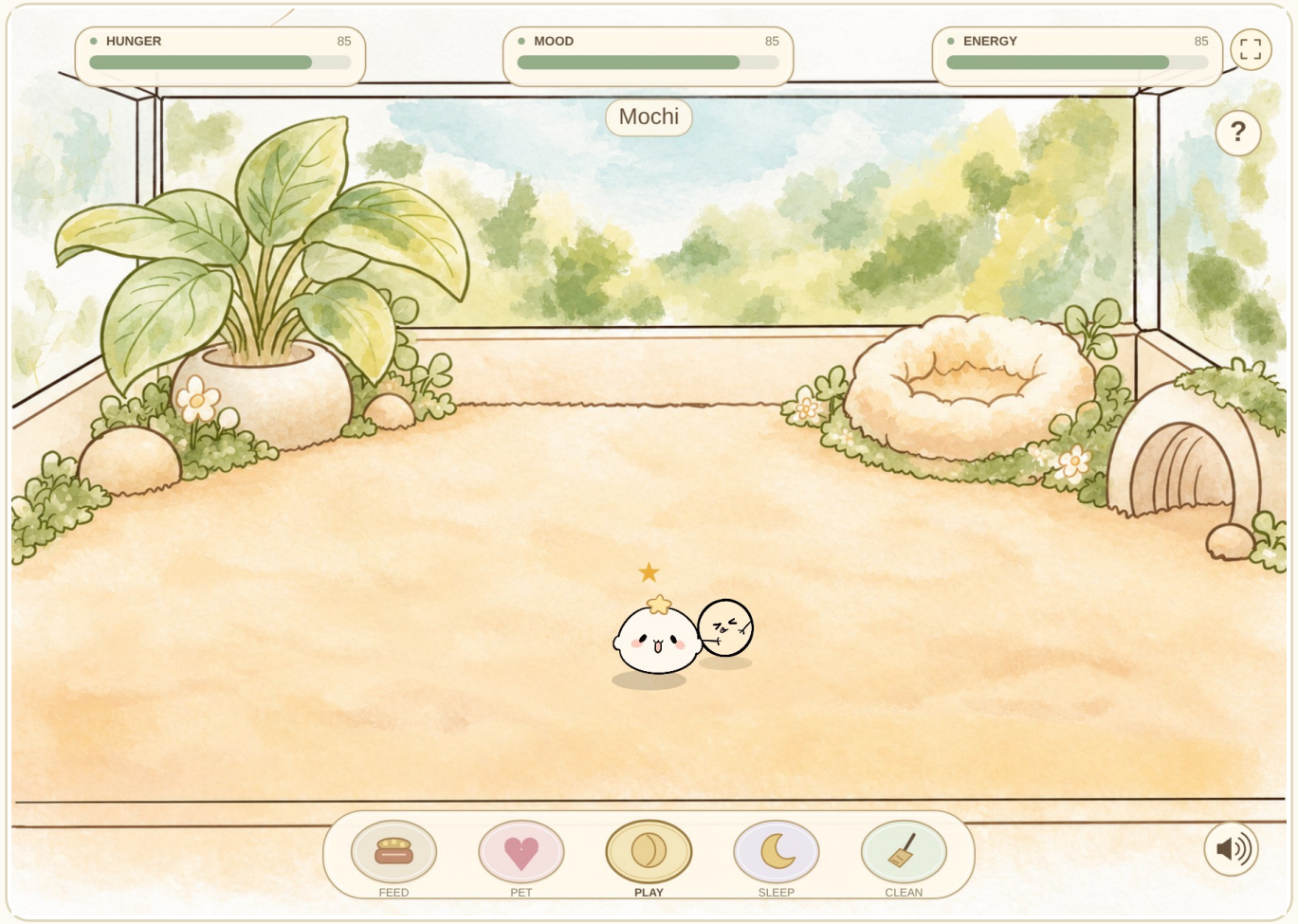


Refuses

An angry dodge or kick shows a clear boundary.

25% baseline refusal for Youth feeding, petting and play.

Let the pet show and voice its needs



Physical play + sound

Throw → chase → contact → kick + call



Needs become visible

Hunger <30: a flattened body.

C pet · B anger · A cry · D kick · L hum

A life in two minutes

00:00–00:25

Egg, hatch & naming

00:25–00:55

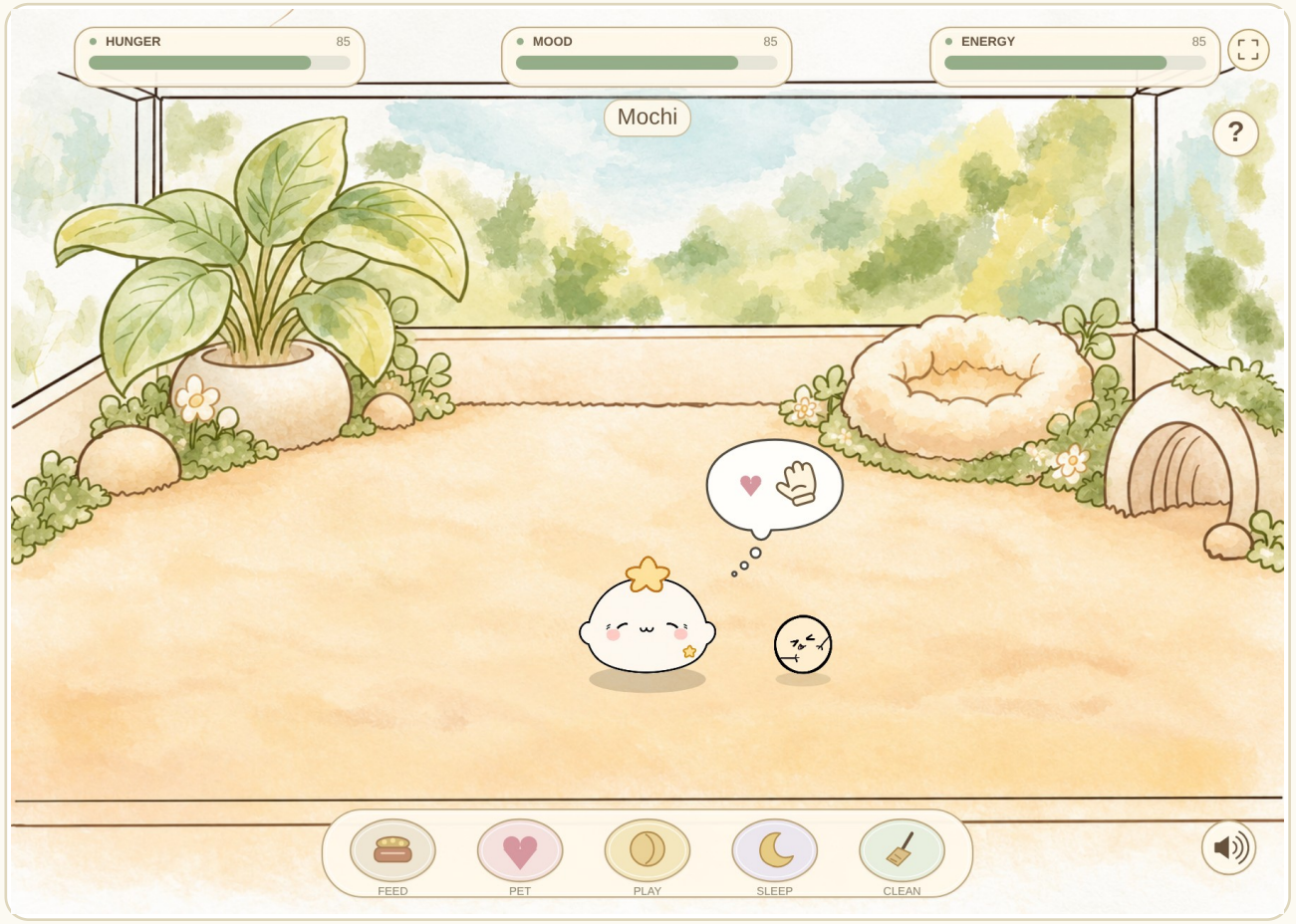
Care & physical play

00:55–01:25

Youth personality

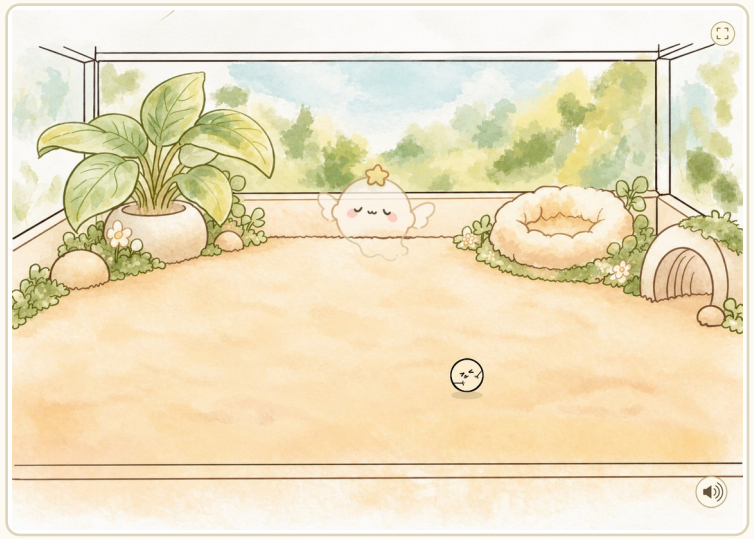
01:25–02:00

Senior & farewell

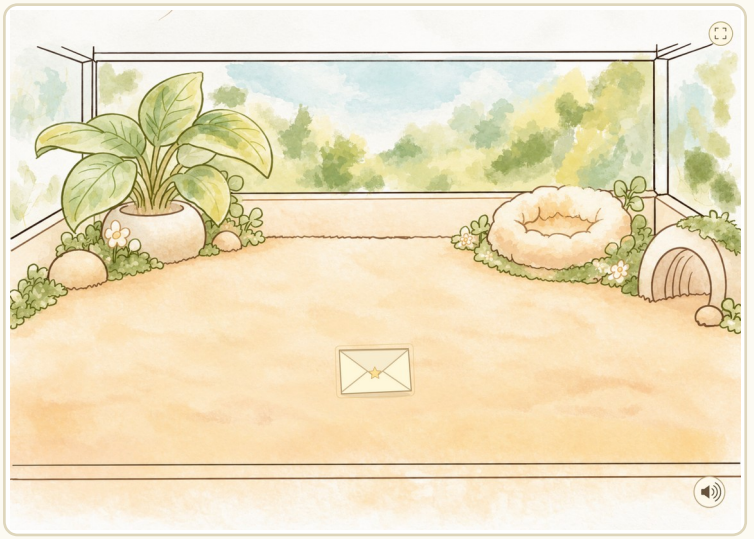


Edited walkthrough • use cuts between stages

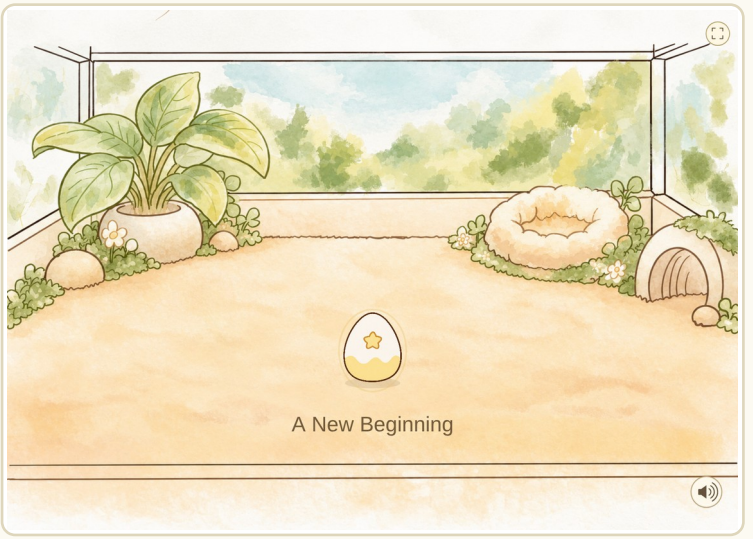
Let the player choose when to say goodbye



Letting go



An invitation to remember



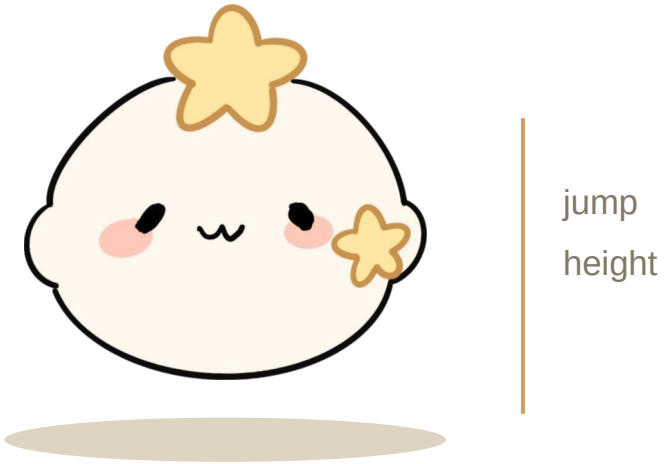
A new beginning

“I’m glad we met.”

The gratitude letter follows natural old age; neglect has a different ending.

Build spatial movement with 2D tools

Depth from 2D rules



Scale by depth • sort by floor Y • anchor shadows

Care & childhood growth

sketch.js + stages.js

Recorded pet calls

sound-effects.js · native audio

Arrival & goodbye

hatching.js + ending.js

Window fit & full screen

style.css + viewport.js

900 × 640 internal coordinates • aspect ratio preserved

Make each reaction feel intentional

What changed

Toy play

Remote-looking pursuit → visible contact kick

Childhood growth

3 feeds + 3 pettings → sleep → grow

Sound & rest

Native calls + automatic child sleep <30

What still needs testing

Do people discover dragging?

Can they understand a refusal?

Does the goodbye arrive too soon?

Next: audience testing, pacing, saved progress and accessibility.

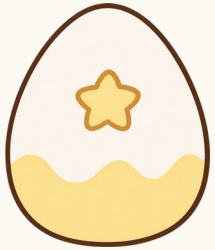
Current evidence: iterative playthroughs and automated browser checks; no formal audience study claimed.

A relationship built from small interactions

A small character.
A changing relationship.



Curiosity → care → attachment → goodbye → renewal



PLAY LITTLE RASCAL ↗️

itsangelia.github.io/little-rascal/

References and production credits

References & process transparency

DESIGN FRAMEWORK

Norman, D. A. (2004). Emotional Design: Why We Love (or Hate) Everyday Things. Basic Books.

IMPLEMENTATION

p5.js documentation — https://p5js.org/reference/

Little Rascal source — https://github.com/itsangelia/little-rascal

REFERENCE & ASSETS

My Lil' Bastard: supplied gameplay reference. Uploaded illustrations and iterated generated assets inform the final visual direction.

AI & AUDIO

OpenAI assistance: coding/debugging and image exploration. Final disclosure should follow course policy. BGM + uploaded voice excerpts: source and licence credits need confirmation.

Appendix • do not read aloud. Add your own exhibition evidence and personal reflection before submission.